no insurmountable contradiction between homosexuality and Islamic piety – not for Shahim Beg and Ali Quli, nor for Badauni, bitter critic though he was of Akbar's later heresies. Ali Quli was 'following the manners of Transoxiana', writes Badauni, as an aside more than a reproach. Love between men wasn't reprehensible in Central Asia. Babur's first love was a young man called Baburi, of whom he wrote, 'I was so bashful that I could not look him in the face.'[63] Bairam Khan, too, did not disapprove of Ali Quli's affections; in fact, he 'took the part of 'Ali Quli Khan and . . . regarded his lawless acts as unacted'.[64]

It is Abul Fazl, the progressive to Badauni's conservative, who bristles at 'the wicked spirits of Transoxiana', and at Ali Quli's temerity in giving 'this outburst of . . . bestial desire the name of Love'. It is Abul Fazl, too, who records that Akbar sent Ali Quli a letter, inviting him to 'repent of your deeds and amend your evil-doings', reinforcing his reproof via 'a number of brave men' sent to appropriate fiefs in Ali Quli's vicinity, and thus keep an eye on him. As it happens, Ali Quli had already assigned one of these fiefs to one of his own men, who did not surrender his claim without a fight.

With battles breaking out in his backyard, and the wild throbbing of his heart shaking the scaffolding of Akbar's nascent kingdom, Ali Quli sent an emissary to Delhi. This man, one Burj Ali, did not plead his case before Bairam or Akbar. Like Sikandar Suri in Mankot, he approached Pir Muhammad. Bairam Khan's deputy's career was careening upwards: he was 'all powerful', writes Abul Fazl, and cruel, as Burj Ali would discover.

Pir Muhammad had Ali Quli's emissary beaten and thrown off a tower. Not content with killing the man, Pir Muhammad made a callous little pun on his name, too; 'Burj' means 'tower'.

A battle and an execution already in its wake, Ali Quli's love affair was about to enter its final, tragic, act.

Though Abul Fazl insists that 'the wicked ways of Transoxiana' are bereft of all worthy emotion, 'neither consuming nor melting, neither love nor friendship', few readers will deny that Ali Quli's love for Shahim possessed such noble qualities, sometimes in too great a measure. At some point, his previously pious knight shifted his affections from God to a dancing girl called Aram Jaan. Aram Jaan was not only 'very fascinating, and graceful in her movements', as Badauni puts it, she was also Ali Quli's wife. But what